

WOMEN'S FAVOURITE
CM Chouhan meets women during AN election campaign in Mandla, Nov. 10

to wield influence in the surrounding seats. Eventually, the strategy paid off, with just two of these MPs—Faggan Singh Kulaste in Mandla and Ganesh Singh in Satna—losing their seats. Other contestants—Narendra Singh Tomar, Rao Uday Pratap Singh, Kailash Vijayvargiya, Prahlad Patel, Riti Pathak and Rakesh Singh—not only won their seats, but often helped the party win adjoining seats.

The BJP also seems to have used Union minister Jyotiraditya Scindia to its advantage. In 2018, the Congress had won 26 of the 34 seats in the Gwalior-Chambal region where Scindia holds sway. With him leaving the party for the BJP in March 2020 along with 19 loyalist MLAs (22 in all), pulling down the Kamal Nath government in the process, the Congress tally was reduced to 16 in the region while the BJP had 18.

Simultaneously, the state unit, headed by V.D. Sharma, was asked to prepare workers for the upcoming battle. A booth-strengthening exercise was undertaken at almost all the 65,000 booths, which were digitised. A feedback system at the BJP office in Bhopal was set up wherein booth in-charges and *panna pramukhs* could be spoken to and their work cross-checked. The booth in-charges were also tasked with spreading awareness among voters about government schemes and how to apply for them. This ensured last-mile connectivity and delivery of schemes.

THE PLAN FOR MP WAS PUT IN PLACE SOON AFTER THE BJP'S KARNATAKA POLL DEBACLE. IT ALSO HEEDED THE LESSONS OF 2018 WHEN IT HAD LEFT THE CAMPAIGN FOR THE STATE TO RUN

The Grand Old Party, too, had begun a similar booth-level exercise. But it left the task of appointing in-charges to MLAs and district in-charges appointed for the specific purpose. Loyalty to the party became second to loyalty towards leaders and, eventually, contestants were left to make fresh appointments to man booths on voting day.

The BJP also made an early start in announcing candidates—by mid-August, it had awarded tickets in 39 assembly segments. This was done after grading the constituencies according to their strength—the ones the party had not won in the past two elections were picked out for the first list. This was the first time the party had announced seats so much in advance. Conventional political logic warrants delayed ticket distribution to manage infighting. The